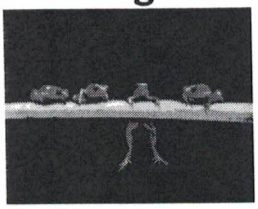
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Forensicator Forever

by David Ralph

Excuse me. I'm sorry, I don't mean to interrupt your round, but I didn't see a waiting line, so I figured it would be o.k., since you're probably in that time of the round when the early ones are done and the others are all waiting to make that final last impression. I know how you feel.

I just wanted to see this room again. I used to live around here when I was in high school. I'm only passing through though on my way to New York. I heard there was a tournament going on so I thought I might sneak in; remember the good times; this room. It was in this room where I won the State Championship in "Serious Solo Acting." That still sounds funny to say.

You're doing a fine thing here you know. It's hard to find judges; people don't like the pressure of judging others, I think it stems from the bible, "Let he whom is without sin cast the first stone!" Oh you'll do fine, just remember to write some comments for improvement and tell them why you ranked them the way you did. The kids really do want your advice on how they can get better.

I remember when I first started; I thought this whole thing was a joke. I was one of those "troubled" kids. I would always get picked on for being so thin but I thought differently than everyone else; I was wirery. Every time some big *uber*-jock would call me *stick figure* or *toothpick* I'd make sure to punch him in the nose as hard as my little stick harms could before the inevitability of nature would take over and my "victim" would use me as a bat to test the sturdiness of the schools pasty brick walls.

God, I despised school. One day I was grabbed by a teacher I really only knew by reputation. I had heard about his threats to tear peoples' spleens out so when he grabbed me I thought for sure he wanted a *stick-figure* beat down, but instead he used some sort of psychic professor power to get me to join something called forensics. He didn't really describe it he just told me it was fun and I would be good at it. I joined because my mom told me forensics was cutting up dead bodies and figuring out how someone was murdered. Sounded fun to me, but when I walked into the classroom the next day I thought, "DO DO DO DO, Welcome to the Twilight Zone."

Kids were talking to the walls and others acted as if they had schizophrenia; this one girl was screaming at the wall one minute and then in some manly voice telling it to shut up. I felt cheated; there weren't any dead bodies to dissect. For a minute I honestly thought I was in the special-ed class.

Eventually, I figured out what the class was all about, which you might be figuring out for yourself today, since there aren't any dead bodies in Serious Solo Acting. SSA; my favorite event to make fun of. Everyone that did it had some major issues. All they ever talked about was eating disorders, suicide, HIV, getting raped or raping, being abused or abusing, or the catch all I guess would be "insert disorder here" that leads to a horrible and painful death. And of course while you're talking about those horrible topics you had to scream and cry at least once or you weren't any good.

Really who, besides mentally disturbed people, would willing do this event? Who would be willing watch something so emotionally disturbing? No offense; I'm sure this is a great round without all those depressing topics and the screaming.

My coach must have thought I was mentally disturbed because he forced me to do a serious piece. My fun and light-hearted topic was horrible death by brain tumor. He must have been using his psychic brain powers again to set up some bizarre foreshadowing of my life when he handed me my script.

My coach taught me that, "Serious Solo Acting is about created emotional levels and being able to tap into those real emotions. It's your chance to truly feel what other's have felt and then share that with an audience." I thought his speech was sarcastic, I mean what would a kid know about brain tumors and death?

I practiced and I even talked to the wall. My coach, who hardly ever gave compliments, said I was pretty good, but, and there was always a but, I didn't seem to grasp the feelings well enough. I told him that I wasn't going to scream or cry because that just seemed silly to me.

The day before my first competition my coach took me to the KU Medical center just down the road. I met a boy named Zach Davidson, who was about my age and he was dying of a tumor in his brain. Zach's story was amazing. For someone who only two years prior had lost his parents only to then be diagnosed with a deadly disease, he was amazing. We talked for hours about life, the seriousness of his condition, my acting piece and how forensics was not about DNA; he even let me rub his bald head. He was full of smiles and his laugh was one you could never forget; it was contagious as it reached the highest of octaves. He was good person. He didn't deserve his condition. He didn't deserve all the pain and suffering.

When I left Zach's room I could see the sadness and loneliness of the hospital take over his smile and for the first time, as far back as I could remember, I cried. I couldn't help it, just like I can't help it now. I wanted to do something for him, but I couldn't. I was beginning to understand what life was about. I was beginning to realize the importance of truly feeling the emotional levels of others; of life.

The next day at competition I blew everyone away with my piece, because I was true to the character in the script. Every word I spoke came from the once locked up vaults of my heart. I hit every emotional level and for a moment I could understand Zach Davidson because I could feel his pain. It wasn't just a performance for a rank it was my chance to share with my audience the real pain that Zach was going through.

I won the State Championship that year but I gave the medal to my inspiration. He told me that it meant a lot to him and I told him that he meant a lot to me; he gave me the ability to feel. The same year I won state was the same year that Zach lost his battle with the tumor. At his funeral his caretakers thanked me for being there for Zach when all his other friends stopped coming to visit; they said just my visiting really lifted his spirits. I couldn't say anything I could only think about how he touched my spirit.

I guess you could say forensics prepared me for life more than any other class I ever took. I don't know how he did it but my coach must have known forensics would turn me around. You know, I still have one of my last ballots. It says, "I know, with your talent, you're going to be a star." I kept that ballot because I wanted it to come true and in a way it did. Instead of being labeled as a trouble maker and a high school failure, I graduated and even went on to college. Now I'm a talent manager and the creator of the Zach Davidson Foundation. Zach's foundation has raised millions for research and hopefully will find a cure for each and every type of body tumor. I can hear Zach's laugh with every dollar raised.

Oh, sounds like you have someone waiting to perform. Thanks for letting me see the room and sorry for rambling on; huh, I probably sounded a little like a Serious Solo myself. Good luck with the ranking thing, just remember what I told you before about the comments and you'll do fine, and if you can't think of anything just write *need more levels*; their coaches will understand.

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